

CORE FORMULA

Recognition + a small warm or context signal + a clean purpose bridge. -> Good to see you. Quick one - I wanted to ask about Friday. -> Thanks for making time. I know your day is packed, so I'll keep this tight. -> Nice to meet you. I heard you're the person who knows this area well. -> Before I jump in, I appreciate you being open to talking this through. -> This is slightly awkward to raise, but I'd rather do it clearly and respectfully.

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Offer a simple greeting plus one warm, relevant line, then bridge straight to why you are there.

BEST FOR

- First meetings, calls, messages and re-opened conversations.
- Starting a request, feedback, disagreement or negotiation without sounding abrupt.
- Networking, dating and social interactions, work conversations and leadership moments.
- Moving from small talk into substance while keeping the warmth.
- Repairing slight awkwardness after silence, an interruption or a cold start.

PHRASE BANK

Quick / low-pressure · Quick / low-pressure phrases

- "Good to see you. Quick one..."
- "Thanks for making time. I'll keep this brief."
- "I know you're busy, so straight to the useful bit."
- "Before we get into it, good to see you."
- "Quick check-in before I ask something."
- "Got a second? Nothing heavy."
- "One quick thing while I've got you."

Social / casual · Social / casual phrases

- "Good to see you - how's your day actually been?"
- "Nice to run into you. What have you been up to?"
- "I was hoping I'd get to ask you about this."
- "You look like you've had a full day."
- "I'm glad we got a minute to talk."
- "It's been too long - I've been meaning to catch you."
- "Good to meet you. How do you know everyone here?"

Professional / workplace · Professional / workplace phrases

- "Thanks for making time. The thing I wanted to cover is..."
- "Good to connect. I'll give you the short version first."
- "I appreciate you looking at this with me."
- "Before the details, here's the main point."
- "I wanted to get your read on something specific."
- "Thanks for making time. The main thing I want to settle is..."
- "I'll give you the useful version first, then you can tell me if detail would help."

Requests · Requests phrases

- "Can I ask a small favour?"

- "Would you be open to a quick ask?"
- "I wanted to ask something specific and easy to answer."
- "No pressure if not, but I wanted to check..."
- "I'll make the ask clear so it's easy to say yes or no."
- "One specific question, and it's an easy yes or no."

Conflict / difficult topics · Conflict / difficult topics phrases

- "I want to raise this carefully, not make it heavier than it needs to be."
- "I value the relationship, so I'd rather be direct and respectful."
- "This may be a bit uncomfortable, but I think it's worth saying clearly."
- "Before I respond, I want to acknowledge this matters."
- "I'm not trying to attack the person; I want to sort out the issue."
- "I want to raise this carefully because I think it matters."

High-status / busy person · High-status / busy person phrases

- "I know your time is tight, so I'll be brief."
- "Bottom line first, then I can give detail if useful."
- "I have one specific question."
- "I'll keep this to two minutes."
- "The reason I'm bringing this to you is specific."
- "I know your time is tight. One specific question..."

Digital / text · Digital / text phrases

- "Quick ask - no pressure if today is too full."
- "Thought of you because of your point about X."
- "Hope your week is going okay. One specific question..."
- "Can I get your quick read on this?"
- "Short version: I'm trying to decide between X and Y."
- "No rush on this - whenever suits."

Re-open after silence · Re-open after silence phrases

- "Picking this back up from the other day..."
- "I wanted to come back to what we were discussing."
- "I realised I left this hanging."
- "Circling back, because your point stuck with me."
- "Before we move on, I wanted to return to one thing."
- "Picking this back up from our last chat - your point about X stuck with me."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

- Weak: Heyyyyy! Hope you're amazing! Sorry to bother you, this will only take a second...
Better: Hey, hope your day's going okay. Quick ask...
Best: Hey, quick ask - no pressure if today's full.
- Weak: How are you? Good? Great. Anyway, I need...
Better: Good to see you. I wanted to ask about...
Best: Good to see you. I'll keep this simple - I wanted your read on...
- Weak: Sorry, sorry, I know you're busy, sorry, can I...
Better: I know you're busy, so I'll be brief.
Best: I know your time is tight. One specific question...
- Weak: We need to talk.
Better: Can we talk through something quickly?
Best: I want to raise something directly, but not make it dramatic.

DECISION TREE

If They respond warmly.

Continue naturally into the conversation or ask; don't over-explain the opening.

"Great - so the thing I wanted to check is..."

If They seem rushed.

Shift straight to the bottom line.

"Quick version is..."

If They seem guarded.

Clarify your purpose and lower the stakes.

"I'm not trying to put you on the spot. I just wanted to ask one thing."

If They ask "What do you need?"

Drop the warm-up and state the clean request.

"Fair enough - could you review the one-page version by Thursday?"

If They seem irritated.

Acknowledge the time or pressure, then shorten or defer.

"I can tell it's a bad moment - shall I catch you later?"

If They engage with small talk.

Follow one live thread, then bridge back to your purpose.

"Sounds like a week. On that note, the thing I wanted to raise is..."

SCENARIOS

Social first contact

Offer one warm observation, then an easy question. — "Good to meet you. How do you know everyone here?"

Work meeting

Respect their time, orient, then state your purpose. — "Thanks for making time. The main thing I want to settle is..."

A difficult issue

Let warmth mean respectful directness, not cheerfulness. — "I want to raise this carefully because I think it matters."

High-status or busy person

Keep the warmth compact and the relevance high. — "I know your time is tight. One specific question..."

Digital message

Lead with a brief human line, then a clear ask. — "Quick ask - no pressure if today is full."

Re-opening after silence

Acknowledge the gap and reconnect with the earlier thread. — "Picking this back up from our last chat - your point about X stuck with me."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- Urgency or safety needs immediate directness.
- The other person is clearly rushed and just needs the bottom line.
- Warmth would be used to soften a dishonest ask or hide pressure.
- You are overdoing friendliness because you feel anxious or approval-seeking.
- The conversation is already emotionally serious and cheerfulness would feel mismatched.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Learn the formula

Say the minimum viable move aloud three times - a simple greeting plus one warm, relevant line. Notice how short it can be and still land.

Day 2 — Write your openers

Write a warm opening for three people you'll actually speak to today, each following Recognition + warm signal + purpose bridge.

Day 3 — Cut the padding

Take yesterday's lines and delete every "sorry", "just", and "quick question if that's okay". Keep the warmth, lose the shrinking.

Day 4 — First request of the day

Before your first ask of the day, use a 10-second warm opening. Afterwards, check: did I recognise the person and bridge to purpose early?

Day 5 — Match the temperature

Use a warm opening on a busy or serious person. Make warmth mean calm and concise, not upbeat. Note whether the tone actually fit.

Day 6 — Practise a recovery

After a deliberately over-long opening, practise one recovery line: "I'm giving too much preamble - quick version is..."

Day 7 — Re-open a cold thread

Use a warm opening to restart a conversation that went quiet, reconnecting to the earlier thread. Watch whether they re-engage more easily.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I open warm because it fit the moment, or because I was anxious and performing?
- Was my wording shorter than my instinct?
- Did the person have more room after my move, or less?
- Did I bridge to purpose early, or let the warmth drift?
- Did I adjust if they became closed, pressured or rushed?
- What neighbouring technique would have been better if this one missed?